

Domain Trust Recovery

Issue: Cannot log in. "The trust relationship between this workstation and the primary domain has failed." No local admin access available.

Decision Tree

```
User cannot log in → domain trust error displayed?
■■■ YES → Do you have local admin credentials for this machine?
■   ■■■ YES → Log in as local admin → FIX A
■   ■■■ NO → Can you boot to Safe Mode with Networking?
■   ■   ■■■ YES → Try domain login in Safe Mode (cached creds may work)
■   ■   ■   ■■■ WORKS → Open elevated PowerShell → FIX A
■   ■   ■   ■■■ FAILS → OFFLINE FIX
■   ■   ■■■ NO → OFFLINE FIX
■   ■■■ UNKNOWN → Try .\Administrator with blank password or last-known local admin
■■■ NO → Not a trust issue. Check network, DNS, DC reachability first.
```

FIX A: Reset Trust (requires local admin or cached domain login)

Option 1 — PowerShell (fastest):

```
Test-ComputerSecureChannel -Repair -Credential (Get-Credential)
```

Enter domain admin credentials when prompted. If it returns **True**, reboot and test.

CMD equivalent (uses netdom, which uses the same NetLogon reset under the hood):

```
:: verify the channel first
nltest /sc_query:domain.local
:: repair by resetting the machine password against a specific DC
netdom resetpwd /server:DC01.domain.local /userd:DOMAIN\AdminAccount /passwordd:*
```

*Microsoft note: **Test-ComputerSecureChannel** works only on domain MEMBER computers and returns false-positive errors on Domain Controllers. On a DC, use **nltest** (**nltest /sc_query:domain.local**) or **netdom** instead.*

Option 2 — Reset the machine password (Microsoft's documented fallback):

```
Reset-ComputerMachinePassword -Server DC01.domain.local -Credential (Get-Credential)
```

This resets the local computer account password and writes the new value to AD in one step. Use it when Option 1 returns **False**. (`netdom resetpwd /server:DC01.domain.local /userd:DOMAIN\AdminAccount /passwordd:*`` does the same from cmd.)

Option 3 — Re-join domain (last resort before reimaging):

PowerShell:

```
Remove-Computer -UnjoinDomainCredential (Get-Credential) -Force -Restart
# After reboot:
Add-Computer -DomainName "domain.local" -Credential (Get-Credential) -Restart
```

CMD:

```
:: unjoin to a workgroup, then reboot
netdom remove %COMPUTERNAME% /domain:domain.local /userd:DOMAIN\AdminAccount /passwordd:* /force
shutdown /r /t 0
:: after reboot, from an elevated prompt, join again:
netdom join %COMPUTERNAME% /domain:domain.local /userd:DOMAIN\AdminAccount /passwordd:* /reboot
```

OFFLINE FIX: No local admin, Safe Mode fails

1. Boot from Windows PE or USB recovery media.
2. Enable the built-in Administrator account via offline registry editing.
3. Reboot, log in as built-in Administrator, use FIX A.

Alternative: If you have remote management tools (SCCM, Intune, ManageEngine) that work outside of user login, push a script to reset the secure channel or re-enable a local admin account.

Prevention

- Ensure machine account password renewal is not blocked by GPO.
 - Machines off-network for 30+ days risk machine account password expiration (60-day default).
 - Maintain a standardized local admin or LAPS break-glass account on all endpoints.
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